

- Were there moments where the theory clarified something you had previously been confused about? What was it?

“The Theory Failed Me” vs. “I Failed the Theory”

This distinction is the heart of the assignment, and it is the hardest part of the reflection.

When living a theory is hard, the easy conclusion is that the theory is implausible. But this conclusion needs to be earned. There are at least three reasons living a theory might be hard, and only one of them tells against the theory:

1. *The theory makes genuinely unreasonable demands.* This is a real philosophical objection – but only if you can show that the demands are unreasonable rather than merely uncomfortable.
3. *You didn’t really try.* The theory wasn’t the problem; your engagement with it was. This is not an objection to the theory.
4. *The theory presupposes practical wisdom or character you don’t yet have.* The theory might be perfectly correct, but living it requires capacities (perception, judgement, virtuous habits) that aren’t built in a day. The fact that *you* can’t live it well isn’t evidence the theory is wrong.

A good reflection takes seriously which of these is going on, rather than collapsing them into “this theory is implausible because I found it hard.”

Common Failure Modes

- **Performance art.** Treating the day as a stage on which to enact the theory dramatically, rather than as an honest experiment in moral living. The audience for this assignment is not the class; it is yourself.
- **Manufactured dilemmas.** Constructing or engineering situations *during the day* to make the assignment philosophically interesting. This defeats the assignment. The point is to engage with the moral texture of the day you would otherwise have had, not to stage-manage a day that produces good philosophical anecdotes. If your day was mostly mundane, the interesting question is what the theory has to say about mundane life.
- **Cherry-picking.** Reporting only the decisions that make the theory look good (or look bad, if that’s the story you want to tell) and omitting the rest.
- **Theory-shaped conclusions you already held.** If your reflection on the theory looks suspiciously like the view you had of it before the assignment began, something has gone wrong. The assignment should *move* your view of the theory – perhaps not by much, and perhaps not in the obvious direction, but it should move it. If it hasn’t, you probably weren’t really living it.
- **Reflection in the abstract.** Reflecting on the theory rather than on the *experience of trying to use it*. The assignment isn’t asking you to write a critique of the theory; it’s asking you to report what trying to live it actually told you.

